2. Boy to Man

Suddenly, I was alone. My parents said their farewells, turned, and were gone. My companions, as I sat on my bed in the dormitory at the St Paul's Cathedral choir school, were a brown teddy bear and a soft rubber cube, which I would gnaw when I was nervous, and throw at the wall when I needed catching practice.

I was aged eight. I felt awkward, confused, horrible. When I started to cry someone asked me whether I was homesick. 'No, I'm not sick of home,' I replied, with childish logic. 'I want to go home.' I would never want my children to experience that feeling, but there is absolutely no doubt the experience made me the cricketer I became.

It was pretty brutal. Even on that first evening, when I longed for the certainties of life in the Essex village of Wickham Bishops, we were expected to buckle down to choir practice. There was no gentle transition to this other world, just immediate immersion in the disciplines of our new craft. We were expected to learn quickly about the power of concentration and performing under pressure.

Choir practice, with vocal techniques and sight-reading, began at 7.45 a.m., before a normal six-and-a-half-hour academic day started at 9 a.m. We would practise for forty-five minutes until 5 p.m., when we would participate in the hour-long Evensong service. Supper provided half an hour's respite and preceded ninety minutes of academic homework and music practice. Lights were out at 9 p.m.